GLASSHOUSE

WAR OF THE OLD GUARD



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Thespian **Rajinikanth's** political ambitions may have come to nought, but that hasn't stopped him from giving pointers to those still in the game. At the August 24 book release event for *Kalaignar Enum Thai* (Kalaignar, the Mother), marking the birth centennial of the late DMK leader M. Karunanidhi, Rajini couldn't resist a jab at the party's old guard. "Old students cause problems by refusing to leave class even after topping the ranks," the 73-year-old quipped, subtly suggesting that party veterans should make way for young blood. Sure enough, the latter didn't take kindly to the barb. Water resources minister Durai Murugan, 86, shot back, "Senior actors keep hogging the limelight until they lose their teeth and drop dead, denying roles to younger talent." Last heard, the two veterans had patched up, saying theirs was, ahem, a very old friendship.

Grave Concerns



Rahul Gandhi's wait for a new home just got a little longer. After losing his MP status last year (he was convicted in the Modi surname defamation case), Rahul had vacated his 12, Tughlaq Lane bungalow and moved in with mother Sonia Gandhi at 10, Janpath. Even after the disqualification was revoked, he continued to stay there. Now, as Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, he's eligible for a Type 8 bungalow, befitting his Cabinet minister rank. The bungalow at 13, Sunehri Bagh, occupied by ex-Union minister Santosh Gangwar, was considered suitable, and as the BJP leader was in the process of vacating it, Rahul came for an inspection. But the visit took a spooky turn when Gangwar's astrologer, who was present, revealed that it was built over a graveyard. Not the ideal foundation for Rahul's new pad.

Minister on Track



Union railways minister **Ashwini Vaishnaw** has of late become the face of public briefings for the Modi government's successive cabinet decisions. It's not always that he speaks on matters directly tied to his own ministries. However, while announcing the Unified Pension Scheme, Vaishnaw found a direct link—the Indian Railways has one of the highest numbers of pensioners among central utilities. Insiders reveal that Vaishnaw played a key behind-the-scenes role in shaping the new policy.

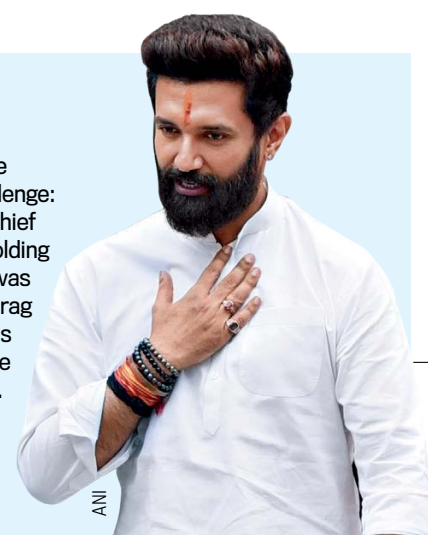


Capital Chase

Andhra Pradesh chief minister **N. Chandrababu Naidu** has set December 1 as the deadline to restart construction on the greenfield state capital, Amaravati. The CM is aiming to complete the project in four years—just in time for the next assembly election. To align with the original vision drafted by London-based architects Foster & Partners, costs are being trimmed to focus on priority projects. However, a glaring uncertainty persists: the estimated cost of Rs 60,000 crore. The only potential funding source is a soft-term loan from the World Bank, which is currently assessing the ground situation before deciding on whether to lend.

Chirag's Chessboard

After Nitish Kumar's JD(U) evinced interest in contesting the Jharkhand assembly election, the BJP faces another challenge: managing the ambitions of another Bihar ally, LJP (Ram Vilas) chief **Chirag Paswan.** The latter has already upped the ante by holding the LJP national executive in Ranchi (on August 25), where he was promptly re-elected party president for another five years. Chirag also hinted at his next move: contesting the state polls, either as part of the National Democratic Alliance or independently. In the previous Jharkhand polls, the BJP gave its Bihar allies nil seats. But with their current influence in the Lok Sabha reduced, the saffron force may have to be a bit more accommodating.



ANI

Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Avishek G. Dastidar and Amitabh Srivastava